Signs and symptoms of mental depression

- Loss of self confidence and self esteem
- Anxiety
- Not being able to enjoy things that are usually pleasurable or interesting

Lifestyle changes like exercise, meditation, yoga and healthy food habits can help to be relieved from depression. Exercise stimulates the body to produce **serotonin** and **endorphins**, which are neurotransmitters that suppress depression. Practicing exercise in daily life creates a positive attitude .

Participating in an exercise programme can:

- Increase self-esteem
- Boost self-confidence
- Create a sense of empowerment
- Enhance social connections and relationships

Brain is one of the most metabolically active part of the body and needs a steady stream of nutrients to function. A poor diet may not provide the nutrients for a healthy body and may provoke symptoms of anxiety and depression.

7.5 Lifestyle disorders in human beings

The old saying that **"health is wealth"** is truly applicable to human beings. With the changes in life style, there are many emerging medical conditions and diseases that are reducing human longevity. Life style disorder result due to activities involving smoking, alcohol and drug abuse, consuming high fat diet, lack of exercise or living a latent life.

The World Health Organization (WHO) in its report cautions a slow moving public health disaster due to life style disorders in the form of non-communicable diseases like diabetes, cardiovascular and lung diseases. WHO believes that not thousands but millions of people die every year within the age group of thirty to sixty due to life style related disorders.

The following facts will help in better understanding of life style disorders.

- Life style disorder causes **cardiovascular diseases** resulting in 31 percent of global deaths.
- The sedentary life style also causes deficiency of vitamins such as **vitamin D** resulting in fatigue, tiredness, back pain, depression, bone loss, muscle pain, etc,
- Life style disorder also includes **social isolation** resulting in age related problems.
- **Eating junk** foods that have high caloric values, rich in carbohydrates and fat can lead to obesity and early health issues.
- Consumption of processed and packaged food, which lacks in fiber may result in constipation.
- Several people today complain of irritable bowel syndrome with stomach discomfort or pain and trouble with bowel movements, causing diarrhoea. The main cause of irritable bowel syndrome is stress and other illnesses.

Life style modifications

- Avoid eating junk food and foods that have preservatives and colouring agents.
- Physical exercises such as brisk walking and yoga can be done regularly.
- Following medical advice, if any health problems in addition to life style disorders.
- To avoid smoking drugs and drinking alcohol.
- To follow a healthy balanced diet rich in vitamins and proteins.
- 7 – 8 hours of sleep every day is required.

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